Comparatives and superlatives

Objective: To compare people, things and periods of time (past and present) using comparative and superlative forms of adjectives.

The idea in two lines: We use the **comparative** to compare two things and the **superlative** to put one thing at the top of a group of three or more. The form depends on the length of the adjective.

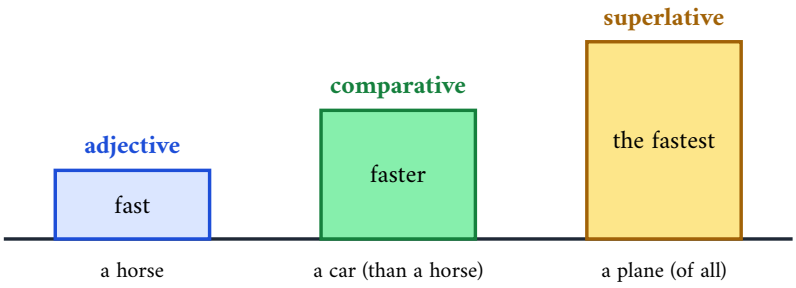


Figure 1: From the adjective to the comparative (two things) and the superlative (the top of a group).

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Short adjectives** (one syllable): add -er / -est: *old → older → the oldest*.
2. **Spelling:** double the final consonant after one short vowel (*big → bigger*); change -y to -i (*easy → easier → the easiest*).
3. **Long adjectives** (most two-syllable adjectives not ending in -y, and all adjectives of three syllables or more): *more / the most*: *modern → more modern → the most modern*.
4. **Irregular forms:** *good → better → the best*; *bad → worse → the worst*; *far → farther/further → the farthest/furthest*.
5. **Equality:** *as + adjective + as*; inferiority: *not as … as* or *less … than*.
6. **Comparative** is followed by *than*; the **superlative** takes *the* and often *in / of*.

🟢 Examples

1. Compare: "Life today / life in the past (easy)". **Answer:** Life today is *easier than* life in the past. **Explanation:** two-syllable adjective ending in -y takes -er.
2. Complete: "Smartphones are (useful) invention of our time." **Answer:** Smartphones are *the most useful* invention of our time.
3. Rewrite with *as … as*: "Old houses were less comfortable than modern ones." **Answer:** Old houses were *not as comfortable as* modern ones.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Double comparison: *more easier* ✕ → **easier** ✓.
- Using *then* instead of **than**.
- Forgetting **the** before the superlative: *It is most modern city* ✕.
- Writing *gooder* or *badder* instead of the irregular forms **better** / **worse**.

🟡 Quick review

- Short: -er than / the -est.
- Long: more … than / the most ….
- good–better–best; bad–worse–worst.
- Equality: as … as; inferiority: not as … as.
- Never mix -er and more.

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